U Nu's Buddhist philosophy may have impeded him from taking action at times. The Buddhist prohibition against doing harm was something that Nu took seriously. This factor made dealing with opponents in a firm way difficult. Buddhist philosophy may have also played into his decision to take a neutralist route in foreign policy.

On a personal level, U Nu was involved in grassroots efforts to promote Buddhism. He restored pagodas, liberated animals, cleansed Buddha images, and sponsored religious ceremonies. Nu even took time off from his position as prime minister to meditate at holy places or monasteries.

The issue of religion, however, was a volatile one. With Muslim, Christian, and animist minority populations, U Nu had to walk a tightrope in dealing with the issue of religion and the state. The Buddha Sasana Council Act provided a way to enforce the government's policies in dealing Buddhism. The Buddha Sasana Council pushed for the resumption of Buddhist religious instruction in state schools and the formation of an inquiry committee to deal with non-Buddhist religious instruction in schools as well. When Nu took steps to ensure the teaching of religions other than Buddhism, such as Christianity and Islam, in the schools, monks blocked these efforts. Nu encouraged the monks and lay protesters to view religion and politics separately. Interestingly enough, Nu would use Buddhism as a way to expel communists from the political process.

The decision to proclaim Buddhism as the official Burmese state religion was delayed for several years. The military was still secular in nature and was facing numerous insurgencies that were non-Buddhist. The fact that Ne Win and others did not want to exacerbate the tension was practical in a time of civil war. It was also the desire of Burma's founding father Aung San to keep a more secular outline in state religious affairs.

THE ROLE OF THE MILITARY (TATMADAW) IN BURMA

By the time of independence in 1948 the Burmese military was seriously factionalized. This would decimate the military for the first two years of independence. The same issues that divided Burmese politics hampered the military. The ethnic divisions as well as ideological disagreements and the issue of power distribution made cooperation problematic.